

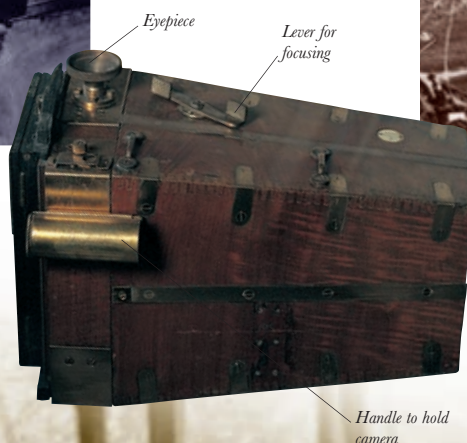


#### HANDHELD BOX CAMERA

A Royal Flying Corps observer demonstrates a Thornton-Pickard "A" Type photo-reconnaissance camera (above). Cameras were initially handheld, using straps or handles (right). Later they were mounted on the aircraft itself.

#### AERIAL VIEW

This photograph (below right) was taken on a reconnaissance mission over France. Once trench warfare set in on the Western Front at the end of 1914, army commanders became totally dependent on aerial reconnaissance for information on what was happening on the other side of no-man's land. "Photo-recce" was a risky business for airmen, requiring slow, straight-and-level flights over enemy positions, repeated many times to build up a complete picture.



turned away from Paris to the east. This information enabled General Joseph Gallieni, who was in charge of the defense of the city, to launch an attack on the exposed German flank on the Marne that turned the tide of the war. By the end of the fall, the Germans had been driven

back toward the Belgian frontier and the war of movement on the Western Front had come to an end. The armies dug in along a line from the English Channel to Switzerland, where they would stay for the next three and a half years.

During the long agony of trench warfare, with its monstrous artillery barrages and its massed infantry offensives, in which hundreds of thousands of lives were sacrificed

for pitifully small territorial gains, aviation dutifully played the role assigned to it by army commanders. As far as they were concerned, the function of aircraft was to carry out reconnaissance and the closely related role of artillery spotting, as well as to inflict damage on the enemy's soldiers and material through tactical bombing and ground attack.

#### Building a picture

From 1915, photography replaced sketches and notes as a technique for aerial reconnaissance. Aircraft with unwieldy box cameras were dispatched day after day over the front to build up an exact picture of the enemy's trench systems and gun emplacements. Initially the cameras were like those found in photographers' studios, with large glass plates that had to be changed by hand after every shot. This was ghastly work for observers with freezing fingers operating in the gale of the aircraft's slipstream. Later, cameras with a mechanically operated plate change made the observer's job more practical, but photo-reconnaissance remained as hazardous as it was unglamorous. An aircraft held steady and straight for photography presented an inviting target

#### RECONNAISSANCE BRIEF

A British officer briefs the pilot of a B.E.12 on the areas to be photographed on his mission. Most photo-reconnaissance was entrusted to two-seater aircraft, with an observer operating the camera. The pilot of a single-seater B.E.12 would have had a tricky time taking pictures while flying in hostile airspace.

